

20, The Dramatic Termination and Continuation of Classical Iran

Among all classical civilizations, only Iran met its end in a phenomenally bizarre and unconventional manner. Khosrau I (库斯劳一世) passed away in 579 AD; a mere 70 years later, this colossal empire utterly vanished, consumed by the massive Islamic conquests.

Under normal historical circumstances, it is virtually impossible for a **classical empire** (古典帝国) to be completely annihilated such an agonizingly short time after experiencing its zenith. Arguably, even during Khosrau I's reign, the Persian Empire had not yet reached its theoretical absolute peak. Because it is glaringly evident that following his death, the succeeding Kings of Kings did not necessarily possess sufficient means to forcefully patronize the newly emerging landlords while suppressing the aristocracy. Consequently, the grand aristocrats within Persia launched a ferocious counterattack.

Regardless, Iran's subjugation by the Arabs was a phenomenally staggering event. Even the victors made no attempt to conceal their sheer disbelief; Muslim historians unanimously concurred that the monumental battles that crushed Persia were nothing short of "divine miracles" (神迹). Naturally, this catastrophic outcome was forged by factors originating from both the conquerors and the conquered.

Regarding the Arab Muslims acting as conquerors: they had existed on the fringes of **Near East** (近东) civilization (*or more precisely, Near East classical civilization*) for over a millennium. The intellectuals and elites among the Arab tribes had long been exposed to and intimately familiarized with the civilizational achievements of the **Near East**, and monotheism was already widely disseminated. Ever since Rome and Persia commenced their perpetual rivalry, the tribes of the northern Arabian Peninsula had been subjugated either by Rome or by Persia, routinely serving as auxiliary forces (仆从军队) whenever the two empires clashed. Consequently, the Arabs obviously possessed a phenomenally deep understanding of the military apparatuses of both empires.

The Prophet Muhammad (先知穆罕默德) founded Islam, promulgating myriad doctrines and dogmas that were intrinsically highly conducive to **feudalization** (封建化). This systematically and effectively organized the formerly fragmented Arab tribes, forging them into a hyper-cohesive military conquest machine boasting terrifying combat efficacy. It is glaringly obvious that what the Byzantines and Persians confronted was absolutely not a horde of backward, disorganized "savages" slowly migrating; it was a highly organized, tempestuous military invasion.

That the Persian rulers remained oblivious to such a colossal existential threat is perhaps forgivable (*it was indeed phenomenally difficult for them to perceive it in advance*), but their choices regarding grand national strategy were an apocalyptic disaster.

For **classical empires** like Byzantium and Persia, the other was fundamentally not their true mortal nemesis. The forces genuinely capable of subverting the empires were the **barbarians** (蛮族) lurking on the peripheries. The historical reality is that the protracted "back-to-back" (背靠背) standoff between the Romans and the Iranians was, holistically speaking, a mutually beneficial symbiosis. Because, at worst, the empires would only suffer **barbarian** invasions from one specific direction.

The Romans understood this with absolute clarity. Although the national power and civilizational advancement of the Iranian regime had long been light-years ahead of the **barbarians** lurking in the northern forests and steppes, the Roman legions stationed facing Iran were not significantly more

numerous than those defending the North. In the Caucasus region, Romans and Iranians jointly defended against nomadic tribes roaming the South Russian steppes—a strategy that was proven to be phenomenally effective.

For the Persian rulers, maintaining an inward focus on domestic affairs was infinitely more critical than executing reckless, boundless expansionist policies abroad. This was because Iran was actively navigating the critical epoch of class transition. The monarch should have ruthlessly capitalized on this process, maintaining draconian vigilance against the grand aristocracy.

However, Khosrau II (库斯劳二世) made the most catastrophically erroneous choice imaginable. Utterly oblivious to the limits of advance and retreat, he recklessly escalated a war—one in which he already held the moral high ground and could have easily concluded with a highly advantageous peace treaty—into an unrestrained conflict, explicitly posturing to completely annex Byzantium. This suicidal exhaustion of national resources (滥竭国力) yielded absolutely zero benefits. Instead, it left both Byzantium and Persia agonizingly enervated, plunging the internal political landscape of the Persian Empire into even deeper chaos.

Here, I must also neutrally point out that the catastrophic war against Byzantium absolutely cannot be entirely attributed to the sheer stupidity of the Persian rulers. We must acknowledge that the emergence of intense expansionist drives within a *classical empire* is, in a certain sense, historically inevitable. This characteristic of military expansion inherently reaches its absolute climax precisely when the process of class transition is at its most violent.

First, the classical bureaucratic system enables the empire to expropriate massive *surplus of social production* (社会生产剩余), giving rise to unprecedentedly colossal armies. This constitutes the material prerequisite for expansion. Second, the *classical empire* is actively undergoing class transition. During this process, the monarch elevates a massive cohort of professional bureaucrats with highly complex backgrounds. Military expansion provides sufficient material incentives for these "new partners" while minimizing friction with entrenched vested interests. Third, the *classical empire* harbors extreme ideological arrogance, desperate to prove its universal superiority, which provides the ideological scaffolding for expansion. Fourth, the phenomenal technological advancements achieved since the "*Great Expansion*" (大扩张) of the *classical empire's* upper echelons render its superiority over peripheral states glaringly obvious, thereby slashing the costs of expansion.

During the late Sasanian Persian era, with the arrival of the absolute zenith of *classical society* (古典社会), Persian society was inexorably bound to undergo this precise mutation.

Yet, where could the Persians possibly expand? Central Asia at that time, though possessing trade cities, could not remotely compare to the prosperity it would achieve centuries later. Iran and India are not geographically distant, but they are separated by treacherous deserts, mountains, and the Gobi; if one factors in that the capital was located at Ctesiphon (泰西封), the logistical distance becomes even more horrific. Expanding into the regions north of the Greater Caucasus Mountains promised negligible returns, while the geopolitical costs imposed by the harsh terrain were astronomical.

In reality, Persia's primary adversary could only possibly be the Byzantines, because the eastern provinces of Byzantium were among the most phenomenally developed and wealthiest regions on the entire planet at that time. We identically observe that when Persia sought military expansion, it

did not exclusively fixate on Byzantium; it also ferociously contested the Kingdom of Aksum (埃塞俄比亚 / Ethiopia) in southern Arabia to seize dominance over Red Sea trade.

Nevertheless, we remain entirely justified in concluding that even if geographical constraints severely limited the adversaries Persia could select, the Persian Emperor still possessed the absolute capacity to comprehend the wisdom of "knowing when to stop" (知止) after securing a monumental victory, rather than dragging the state straight into the abyss of annihilation.

When the monumental Muslim armies surged northward, the Byzantine Emperor Heraclius (希拉克略皇帝)—recognizing his military inferiority—at least managed to devise a strategy to successfully withdraw his remaining forces back into Anatolia to mount a desperate defense. In stark contrast, the countermeasures deployed by Yazdegerd III (伊嗣埃三世) of Persia were an apocalyptic failure. Completely devoid of rational composure, he obsessively sought to reclaim lost territories and utterly failed to avoid decisive pitched battles when they absolutely should have been avoided. *(To a certain extent, this was perhaps inevitable; Heraclius, after all, had already accumulated formidable military prestige).*

Regardless, the Persian rulers must bear absolute responsibility for failing to distinguish friend from foe and for executing catastrophic strategic blunders. If Zhao Gou (赵构 / Emperor Gaozong of Southern Song), the founding emperor of China's Southern Song Dynasty, had heard the history of the Persian Empire's final 50 years *(though it is highly unlikely he ever did)*, he would have unequivocally mocked the sheer stupidity of the Persian rulers. Where in the world is there an autocratic monarch who cannot discern who his true mortal enemy is, who fails to ruthlessly control his own subordinates, and who refuses to pragmatically retreat and accept a rump state (偏安) when survival demands it.

If Zhao Gou had been ruling the Persian Empire back then, the moment he realized Ctesiphon (泰西封) was indefensible, he undoubtedly would have sprinted deep into the Iranian plateau to "rebuild the nation's rivers and mountains" (重整河山). As for the Arabs, if peace could be purchased with gold, he would have decisively paid them off. Naturally, one can fundamentally never expect the rulers of Sasanian Persia to possess the venomous, infinitely pragmatic political experience accumulated by Chinese emperors during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期).

However, as previously analyzed when discussing the history of Islam, the Arab invaders absolutely did not implement radical **feudalization** measures within the territories of the Persian Empire. The deep social structure of Iran underwent zero fundamental mutation. The **Dehqan** (德赫坎)—the Iranian **landlord class** (地主阶级) that surged to prominence during the late Sasanian Dynasty—continued to actively develop and evolve under Arab imperial rule, comprehensively dominating social production across the Iranian region.

The Arab Empire essentially inherited Iran's classical society intact. This is precisely why Iranian culture was capable of staging a spectacular renaissance when the Arab Empire ultimately disintegrated. In fact, I contend that whether it was Alexander's conquest or the Islamic conquest of Persia, neither inflicted any fundamental mutation upon the true *essence* of Persian society. These conquests were fundamentally incomparable to the apocalyptic disruptions later unleashed by the Turkic and Mongol peoples.

Even under early Arab rule, religious conversion in Iran was agonizingly gradual. It was not until two or three centuries *after* the initial conquest that Islam genuinely began to penetrate the social grassroots; prior to that, the overwhelming majority of the populace remained steadfast adherents of Zoroastrianism (拜火教).

If the rise of Islam had fundamentally never occurred, I believe Iran's **classical empire** would likely have persisted exactly as it did in *Our Timeline* (本位面) right up until the massive migrations of the Turkic peoples. Concurrently, the doctrines and religious laws of Zoroastrianism would likely have undergone a natural mutation into a **feudal religion** (*it is possible this transition had already commenced prior to Persia's fall, though my expertise in this specific area is limited, so I dare not speak in absolutes*), though the ruling dynasty would likely have been overthrown at least once.

Finally, an exceptionally fascinating phenomenon warrants profound attention here. If we proceed according to our current hypothesis—namely, that the **feudalization** process in the **Near East** territories ruled by Byzantium commenced significantly earlier than in the regions ruled by Iran—we might uncover a hidden geopolitical layer regarding why the Arab Empire transferred its capital from Damascus (under the Umayyads) to Baghdad (under the Abbasids). Beyond the explicit historical narratives, could it be that, as the era progressed, the former Iranian territories were structurally far more capable of sustaining a **classical empire**, whereas the degree of **feudalization** in regions like Syria had already grown excessively high? **Was this precise structural advantage the underlying reason the Abbasids succeeded with Iranian support?** However, unearthing direct, irrefutable evidence to substantiate this hypothesis is likely impossible today.

For the Iranians, at least one monumental historical reality remains a source of profound comfort: by the time of the great Islamic conquests, the Iranian **landlord class** had already robustly established itself. Simultaneously, the Arab rulers were entirely content to strike pragmatic compromises with the landlord classes of their newly conquered territories. Consequently, a vast constellation of traditional Iranian culture was meticulously preserved straight into the modern era.

During the epochs marred by frequent Turkic and Mongol invasions, although the military backbone of the regimes consisted entirely of Turkic-Mongol elites, the civil administrative bureaucrats were overwhelmingly, almost exclusively, Iranians. This can perfectly be interpreted as a massive recurrence of the structural compromise between foreign conquerors and the **bureaucratized landlords** (官僚化地主) (*the exact landlord stratum sustaining the bureaucratic apparatus*). Although the Iranians eventually abandoned their indigenous religion, the Islam they revere today is a highly, profoundly "Iranianized" version of Islam.

Equally, it was precisely during these six centuries—spanning from the Arab conquest to the Mongol conquest—that the Iranians ushered in their most spectacularly prosperous era of academia and science. Even the preceding ten centuries of the classical Iranian empires pale in comparison. After all, the sheer geographical expanse encompassed by the Islamic world, and the unprecedented scale of east-west human mobility, commodity exchange, and technological diffusion, were fundamentally unparalleled compared to a millennium prior.

Furthermore, compared to the Fertile Crescent in the **Near East** and Egypt, Iran had not suffered severe civilizational decay since the final millennium BC. Those two regions had been violently reduced to bleeding battlegrounds for competing newly rising **classical empires** for over a millennium (*leading up to the Islamic conquest*), and their indigenous self-identities had long been ground into dust. Although these regions were identically conquered by the Arab Empire, and

compromises undeniably occurred under Arab rule, **what indigenous traditions did they even have left to fiercely defend?**

The Persians, though enduring identical catastrophic disasters, had after all existed as a world-renowned, awe-inspiring *classical empire* for a staggering one thousand one hundred years. **The Iranian landlord class undeniably possessed formidable power and profound motivation to fiercely safeguard its cultural exceptionalism.**

After conducting a fundamental observation of the histories of India and Iran, I believe it is imperative to emphasize one crucial point here. Although we established that both Greater Iran and the Indian subcontinent harbored massive tracts of "unsettled frontiers" (未定边疆), and that this geopolitical reality severely retarded the *feudalization* processes in both regions, a glaring disparity simultaneously exists between Iran and India regarding this dynamic: India's geographical fragmentation and openness were visibly weaker than Iran's, rendering its cultural and ideological consciousness significantly more monolithic (一元化).

The logic behind this is highly apparent. A monumental crisis facing the Indian subcontinent is the torrential precipitation season brought by the tropical monsoons. Massive, short-term deluges obliterate roads, forge impassable natural barriers, and completely sever information transmission, human mobility, and the circulation of supplies. Because political rule remains utterly reliant upon the time-sensitive efficiency (时效性) of information, personnel, and logistics, the subcontinent's brutal environment genuinely and physically strangled the expansion and unification of political regimes.

In stark contrast, the transmission and replacement of culture and religion are fundamentally indifferent to such time-sensitive efficiency. If action is impossible during this monsoon season, simply wait for the next; if progress is blocked this year, proceed the following year. The mutation of social consciousness operates on a generational timescale (以代际为时间尺度); it can absolutely never be obstructed by mere seasonal climatic shifts operating on an annual cycle.

The situation in Greater Iran was astronomically more complex. The convoluted topography and violently shifting environments across the vast expanse stretching from the Caucasus to the Pamirs (帕米尔) did not merely impose insurmountable logistical difficulties upon political rule; they physically and effectively erected impenetrable barricades hindering the transmission and exchange of culture, religion, and language.

One can observe certain ironically fascinating historical facts: for instance, although some Iranians passionately condemn the Islamic conquest of classical Iran, they fundamentally cannot deny that the deep "Iranianization" (*linguistically speaking*) of modern Khorasan (呼罗珊) and parts of Central Asia was exclusively achieved under the rule of the Umayyad and Abbasid Dynasties. Considering Greater Iran's glaringly obvious geographical openness, it is fundamentally unsurprising that its degree of cultural monolithic unity was significantly weaker than that of India.

There is an exceptionally fascinating example within the realm of political concepts. Across the classical languages of various regions globally, precisely three distinct terms emerged denoting the "known world," the "inhabited world," or "all within the four corners." They are: the Greek term "**Oikumene**" (*which later transmitted into Latin*), the Chinese concept of "**Tianxia**" (天下 / **All Under Heaven**), and the Indian term "**Jambudvipa**" (瞻部洲).

These three concepts were birthed, respectively, during the lifetime of Herodotus (希罗多德), during the Western Zhou Dynasty in China (*subsequently flourishing aggressively during the Warring States period*), and around the epoch when the Maurya Dynasty (孔雀王朝) fundamentally unified the Indian subcontinent.

We can observe with absolute clarity that the genesis of such a "Tianxia" concept genuinely originates from a universal imperative: **on the exact eve of the formation of *classical empires* during the late stage of the "Great Expansion" (大扩张), the sheer expansion of the known world and the imminence of political unification forcefully manufactured the demand to invent this concept.** None of these three terms are merely geographical nouns; they are explicitly ideological instruments forged to construct a "**unified moral order**" (统一道德秩序). The *classical empires* that surged in Eastern Asia (China), the Mediterranean world (Greece and Rome), and the South Asian subcontinent (India) possessed a sufficient degree of monolithic unity (一元化程度) across political, cultural, linguistic, and religious domains, thereby ensuring that the concept of "Tianxia" could be universally accepted.

Bypassing convoluted academic definitions, one can evaluate whether a concept is genuinely synonymous with "Tianxia" by applying a highly succinct, necessary but insufficient condition. The *Gongyang Commentary* (《公羊传》)—one of the most paramount texts sculpting classical Chinese ideology—repeatedly invokes the concept that "**for a true king, there is no 'outside'**" (王者无外). This provides a monumental footnote for "Tianxia."

"Tianxia" is fundamentally "without an outside" (无外). That is to say, when a term signifies "Tianxia," there exists absolutely no parallel, corresponding "complementary set" (补集) concept within the interactive, objective world.

For instance, let us examine the Sumerians' concept of the "Land of the Civilized Lords" (文主地). While the Sumerians perceived the plains they inhabited as the epitome of civilization and order, they simultaneously designated the surrounding mountainous regions as *KUR*—a domain of chaos, barbarism, and hostility. Identically, the Egyptians perceived the *Kemet* (科密特 / Black Land) they inhabited as the locus of life, order, and *Ma'at* (玛阿特), while the Red Land (红土地) was the chaotic domain of Seth (赛特). They explicitly believed that beyond Upper and Lower Egypt lay the territory of the enemy, the "Nine Bows" (九弓). The Greeks believed *Hellas* (赫拉斯) consisted of people living together within the politically rational space of the polis (city-state), while the *Barbari* (巴巴里) were mere savages. Our own nation's paired concepts of *Zhuxia* (诸夏 / The Various Xia States) and *Siyi* (四夷 / The *Barbarians* of the Four Quarters) operated on this exact identical logic.

However, for "Tianxia," "Jambudvipa," and "Oikumene," absolutely no such corresponding complementary set exists. It is true that Indians believed that beyond (Southern) *Jambudvipa* lay the Eastern *Videha* (东胜神洲), the Northern *Kuru* (北俱芦洲), and the Western *Godaniya* (西牛贺洲)—but those were utterly inaccessible to ordinary mortals. When the Chinese initially weaponized "Tianxia" on a massive scale, they identically believed that the Lord of Mount Tai (泰山府君) governed the underworld; yet, aside from myths and apocryphal tales, that too was fundamentally not an interactive realm.

The genesis of this "Tianxia" concept occurred **if and only if** the era coincided with the formation of a **classical empire**. Only that specific social stage possessed the capacity to incubate and filter out such a universally utilized geopolitical concept. The conditions for it absolutely did not exist prior to this epoch, nor will they ever return after it. Therefore, throughout all of human history across the globe, there are exclusively only those three words that truly signify "Tianxia": one in the *Book of Documents* (《尚书》), one on the rock edicts of Ashoka (阿育王), and one in the *Histories* of Herodotus.

Compared to China, Rome, and India, from the Achaemenid Dynasty right through to the Sasanian Dynasty, the Persians fundamentally failed to invent a vocabulary equivalent to "Tianxia." Perhaps the closest approximation was the concept of "**Ērānshahr**" (伊朗之境), an expression denoting the territory of the Iranians. Concurrently, the Sasanians actively generated the concept of "**Anērānshahr**" (非伊朗人之境) as its counterpart, and even posited "**Jahānshahr**" (贾汗沙赫尔), a concept of a "world empire."

However, one can glaringly perceive within Sasanian ideology the exact state-building paradigm utilized by early civilizations: **structuring identity upon a binary opposition between the "Self" and the "Barbarian Other"**. Even the proclamation of *Jahānshahr*, much like the titles claimed by the Assyrian Empire and earlier *Near East* monarchs as the "King of the Four Quarters of the World" (天下四方之王), retained a phenomenally high degree of similarity to them—it was purely a personalized, egotistical proclamation. It is even said that the widespread use of the term *Jahānshahr* occurred only after the Arab conquest of Iran.

One can definitively conclude that classical Iran's "worldview" fundamentally failed to distinctively differentiate itself from that of the Bronze Age. Its articulations were hyper-centric on the king (*almost exclusively deployed in royal inscriptions, rather than serving as the "public political language" of the intellectual stratum* (知识分子阶层) *within a classical state*), aggressively emphasizing the monarch's mythological claim of mastering the cosmos. This stands in glaring, diametric contrast to the highly geopolitical, cultural, and profoundly moralized "Tianxia" forged during the formation of *classical empires*, which was deeply steeped in humanistic ideology and universality.

This glaring dichotomy heavily implies that Iran's treacherously complex geographical environment undeniably exerted a massive impact on classical Iranian society. The supreme rulers fundamentally lacked the overwhelming ideological arrogance to genuinely perceive themselves as the "defenders of the known world's order." Instead, they pragmatically settled for being exactly what they called themselves: the "King of Kings."

20, 古典伊朗戏剧性地结束和延续

在所有古典文明中，只有伊朗以一种不同寻常的方式走向结束，库斯劳一世在公元 579 年去世，仅仅 70 年后这个帝国就消失在伊斯兰大征服中。在正常情况下，一个古典帝国不可能在经历过鼎盛时期这么短的时间后就被完全消灭，甚至于即使是库思老一世统治时期波斯帝国还没有到达理论上的顶点。因为人们明显看到在库思老一世去世之后，接下来的万王之王未必有足够的手段去扶持新兴地主打压贵族，波斯境内的大贵族发动了反击。无论如何，伊朗被阿拉伯人征服都是一个非常惊人的事件，即使是胜利者对此也不讳言，穆斯林史学家一致认为当年击垮波斯的重大战役属于神迹。这自然有征服者和被征服者两方面的原因。对于作为征服者的阿拉伯穆斯林来说，他们在近东文明的边缘已经存在了上千年（也可

以确切地说是近东古典文明），阿拉伯民族中的有识之士早已接触并熟悉近东文明的成果，一神教广为传播。自从罗马和波斯相互对抗以来，阿拉伯半岛北部的部落不是从属于罗马就是从属于波斯，作为仆从军队在两个帝国交战时发挥作用，阿拉伯人显然已经足够了解这两个帝国的军事情况。先知穆罕默德开创伊斯兰教，推行了许多利于封建化的教义教规，有效组织了原先分散的阿拉伯各族，使之成为具有强大战斗力和凝聚力的军事征服集团。显然对于拜占庭和波斯人来说，他们面临的绝不是一群野蛮落后的，组织分散的部落逐渐迁徙，而是高度组织化的，疾风骤雨般的军事入侵。

而波斯统治者面对这样巨大的威胁并无感知就算了（他确实也很难感知），在国家战略的选择上更是一塌糊涂。对于拜占庭和波斯这样的古典帝国而言，对方本质上并非自己的仇敌，真正可能颠覆帝国的是那些外围的蛮族。事实就是长久以来罗马人和伊朗人背靠背的局面对于双方总体上说是共赢的，因为帝国充其量只会在一个方向上遭到蛮族的侵略。罗马人非常清楚这一点，虽然长久以来伊朗政权的国力和先进程度都绝不是北方森林和草原里的蛮族能够相比的，但是驻扎在面向伊朗方向的军团并不比防守北方的多。在高加索地区，罗马人和伊朗人共同防御在南俄草原上游荡的游牧民族，这确实被证明是卓有成效的。对于波斯统治者来说，继续关注国内也远远比在国外无度地执行冒进扩张政策要重要得多，因为伊朗正在面临阶级交替的关键时期，君主应该顺势利用这个过程，对于大贵族有所防范。可是库斯劳二世却做出了最错误的选择，全然不知进退，明明已经在可以达成对自己有利条件的议和的条件下结束一场占理的战争，完全没有节制地扩大战争，做出了吞并拜占庭的姿态。这样滥竭国力的行为没有带来任何收益，反而令拜占庭和波斯双方都极为虚弱，波斯帝国的内部局势更加混乱。

这里我也要中立地指出，对拜占庭的战争肯定不能完全归因于波斯统治者的愚蠢。我们必须要注意到的是，古典帝国强烈扩张性的出现是可以说一种必然，特别是在阶级更替最剧烈之时这种军事扩张的特征也达到顶峰。首先，古典官僚体制使得帝国能够获得大量生产盈余，史无前例的庞大军队出现了，这是扩张的物质条件。其次，古典帝国正在经历阶级交替的过程，君主在这个过程中提拔了大量身份复杂的职业官僚，扩张将会在较少触动既得利益的情况下，为新合伙人提供足够的物质激励。第三，古典帝国在意识形态上极度自信，希望证明自己普世的优越性，这为扩张提供了意识形态支撑。第四，古典帝国上层大扩张以来长足的技术进步，使得帝国对于周边国家的优势变得明显，这降低了扩张的成本。在萨珊波斯统治晚期，随着古典社会全盛的到来，波斯社会也必然经历这样一种变化。然而波斯人能够向何处扩张呢？那个时候的中亚虽然已经有贸易城市，但是和几个世纪后的繁荣还没有办法比。伊朗和印度距离不近，但是中间相隔戈壁，沙漠和山区，如果考虑到首都在泰西封的话那就更加险远了。向大高加索山脉以北的地区扩张缺少收益，而地理条件带来的成本又很高。实际上，波斯的主要对手只可能是拜占庭人，因为拜占庭东部省份在当时整个世界上都是极其发达富庶的地区。我们同样看到，波斯在寻求军事扩张的时候不是只盯着拜占庭打，它也在阿拉伯半岛南部同埃塞俄比亚抢夺红海贸易的主导权。只不过我们还是有理认为，哪怕地理环境限制了波斯能够选择的对手，波斯皇帝仍然可以在取得大胜之后明白知止的道理，而不是最终导致国家倾覆。

在穆斯林大军挥师北进的时候，希拉克略皇帝在自知不敌之后至少能够想尽办法组织军队撤回安纳托利亚进行防御，波斯的伊嗣埃三世（Yazdegerd）的对策就很失败了，总是完全不冷静地寻求光复故土，没有在应当避免会战的时候避免会战。（某种程度这也是没办法，希拉克略毕竟已经积攒了不小的军事威望）无论如何，波斯统治者必须为自己敌友不分，策略不明而承担责任。如果南宋开国皇帝赵构听说波斯帝国最后 50 年的事（他不太可能知道），他一定会嘲笑波斯统治者的愚蠢，哪有专制君主分不清谁才是真正的敌人，治不住臣下并且该偏安的时候不偏安的呢？如果让赵构在当年统治波斯帝国，恐怕他一旦发现泰西封保不住就会跑到伊朗高原“重整河山”了吧，至于对阿拉伯人能用钱买来和平就应当果断花钱。当然，的确没有人能指望萨珊波斯的统治者和复辟官僚时期的中国皇帝一样统治经验丰富。

然而就如之前在谈到伊斯兰教历史时所提到的，阿拉伯入侵者并没有在波斯帝国境内采取激进的封建化措施，伊朗社会的结构没有发生大的变化。在萨珊王朝后期兴起的伊朗地主阶级德赫坎（Dehgan）在阿拉伯帝国统治时期继续发展变化，主导了伊朗地区的社会生产，阿拉伯帝国继承了伊朗的古典社会，这也是为什么伊朗文化能够在阿拉伯帝国解体时呈现出复兴局面的原因。我认为实际上无论是亚历山大征服波斯还是伊斯兰征服波斯对于波斯社会的本质都没有造成变化，完全无法与后来的突厥人、蒙古人相比。甚至于在整个阿拉伯统治下的伊朗连宗教都是渐变的，直到征服发生之后两三个世纪，伊斯兰教才开始深入社会基层，此前大部分居民仍是拜火教信徒。如果从来没有伊斯兰教的崛起，那么我认为伊朗的古典帝国可能也会像本位面一样延续到突厥人大范围迁徙时，而拜火教的教义和教法也会像一个封建宗教的自然转化（可能在波斯灭亡前已经在转化了，只不过我对这块确实不了解，也不敢说死），不过王朝可能会更迭一次。最后这里还有一个有趣的现象值得注意，如果我们按照现在的推断，也就是拜占庭统治的近东地区封建化进程要明显早于伊朗统治地区。就会发现从伍麦叶王朝到阿拔斯王朝阿拉伯帝国的首都从大马士革移动到巴格达或许还有另一层原因，那就是随着时代发展原先伊朗地区更能够维持一个古典帝国，而叙利亚这样的地方封建化程度已经太高了，这是否是阿拔斯人在伊朗人支持下能够成功的原因？不过要想找到支持这个观点的直接证据大概是不可能的。

对伊朗人而言至少有一点值得欣慰，毕竟在伊斯兰大征服的时候伊朗的地主阶级已经兴起了，而阿拉伯统治者也满足于对被征服地区的地主阶级妥协，因此伊朗的许多传统文化都保存至今。在突厥人和蒙古人频繁侵入的时期，尽管政权的武力支柱是突厥-蒙古人，但是行政单位的文职人员还基本上都是伊朗人，这也可以被视为征服者和官僚地主（支撑官僚体制的地主阶层）相互妥协的再次出现。伊朗人虽然抛弃了本土的宗教，但是他们如今信仰的伊斯兰教也是高度伊朗化的伊斯兰教。同样也正是在阿拉伯征服到蒙古征服之间的这六个世纪中，伊朗人迎来了学术最为繁荣的时代，即使是之前超过十个世纪的古典伊朗帝国也要相形见绌。毕竟伊斯兰世界所涵盖的范围，东西方人员流动、物品交换以及技术传播的规模都不是早一千年的时候能比的。而与近东新月地区和埃及两地相比，伊朗不像它们一样从公元前最后一个千年就严重衰落了，沦为新兴古典帝国的角逐场已经上千年之久（截止伊斯兰征服），其自我认同早已消磨严重。这两个地区虽然被阿拉伯帝国所征服，妥协想必也在阿拉伯人治下发生了，但是他们还有什么传统需要保卫的呢？波斯人虽然一样屡经灾难但是毕竟作为名震世界的古典帝国存在了一千一百多年之久，伊朗的地主阶级的确能够找到保卫其文化特殊性的动力。

在基本观察过印度和伊朗的历史后，我认为有必要在这里强调一点。尽管我们指出无论是大伊朗还是印度次大陆地区都存在着面积可观的“未定边疆”，这种地缘事实会拖慢伊朗和印度的封建化进程。然而伊朗和印度在这方面又有显著的差异：印度的地理破碎性和开放性显弱于伊朗，就其文化观念而言更为一元化。这个道理是比较显然的，印度次大陆所面临的一个重大问题是热带季风气候所带来的降水季，大量的短时降雨将冲垮道路、形成屏障，阻断信息传播、人员移动和物资流通。政治统治依赖信息传播和人员和物资流动的时效性，因此次大陆的环境确实遏制了政权的扩张和统一。相比之下，文化和宗教的传播和替代并不是那样在乎时效性，这个雨季没有办法行动那就下一个雨季，今年没法行动就下一年。社会意识的变化以代际为时间尺度，远不是以年为周期的季节变化能够阻挡的。大伊朗的情况复杂的多，从高加索延伸到帕米尔的广大地区中复杂的地形地貌与多变的环境不只是对政权的统治造成了困难，而且在文化、宗教、语言的传播交流方面造成了事实上的阻隔。人们可以看到一些啼笑皆非的历史事实，比如虽然一些伊朗人谴责伊斯兰对于古典伊朗的征服，但是他们却没办法否认今天呼罗珊和中亚部分地区的伊朗化（语言上的）正是在伍麦叶和阿拔斯王朝统治下实现的。再考虑到大伊朗地理位置上显然的开放性，其一元化程度更弱于印度就不是值得奇怪的事了。

有一个非常有趣的政治观念上的例子，在世界各地的古典语言中出现了三个不同表示“已知世界”，“有人居住的世界”，“四方之内”的词语，分别是希腊人所使用的“oikumene”（后来又传入拉丁语），中国人所使用的“天下”，以及印度人所说的“瞻部洲”（Jambudvīpa）。这三个词分别诞生于希罗多德生活时期，中国西周时期（在战国时期发扬光大）以及孔雀王朝基本统一印度次大陆前后。我们可以明确看到的是，这种“天下”概念的形成的确出于一种普世的原理，那就是在大扩张晚期古典帝国形成的前夜，已知世界的扩大和政治统一的临近使得创造这个概念的需求被制造了出来。三个“天下”都不是单纯的地理名词，而是一种构建“统一道德秩序”的意识形态工具。中国所在的亚洲东部、希腊、罗马所在的地中海世界和印度所在的南亚次大陆所崛起的古典帝国在政治、文化、语言和宗教等领域具有足够的一元化程度，这确保了“天下”的概念是可以被接受的。

抛开复杂的定义不谈，人们可以通过一个简洁的必要不充分条件去判断一个概念究竟是否与“天下”等同。塑造古典中国意识形态最重要的文本之一《公羊传》中数次提到了“王者无外”这个概念，这为“天下”作出了一个重要的注脚。“天下”是“无外”的，也就是当这个词意表“天下”的时候，在可互动的客观世界之外没有平行的与之对应的“补集”概念。比方说苏美尔人所讲的“文主地”吧，苏美尔人在认为自己生活的平原是文明且秩序的同时，也会指出周边的山地“KUR”是混乱，野蛮和敌对的。与此相同，埃及人把自己生活的“科密特”黑土地视为生命、秩序和玛阿特所在之处，而红土地则是赛特的混沌之地。他们认为在上下埃及之外则是敌人“九弓”的领土。希腊人认为赫拉斯是生活共同生活在城邦这样具有政治理性空间里的人，而巴巴里则是野蛮人。我们国家的诸夏和四夷这组对应概念也是同样的。但是“天下”，“Jambudvīpa”和“Oikumene”不存在这样对应的补集概念。的确，印度人认为在（南）瞻部洲以外，还有东胜神洲，北俱芦洲，西牛贺洲，但那不是常人能去的。中国人在最初大规模使用“天下”的时候，也认为泰山府君掌管着冥界，但是除了传说和逸文，那也不是一个可互动的地方。“天下”这一概念的产生在且仅在古典帝国形成时期，只有那个社会阶段能够催生并筛选出这样被普遍使用的政治地理概念，之前没有条件，之后也不会复来。所以古往今来天下的“天下”只有那三个词，一个在《尚书》里，一个在阿育王的碑文上，一个在希罗多德的《历史》中。

与中国、罗马和印度相比，从阿契美尼德王朝到萨珊王朝波斯人并没有创造出与“天下”相等同的词汇，比较接近的或许是“伊朗之境”这个表达伊朗人领土的概念。与此同时，萨珊人也创造了“埃兰沙赫尔”对应的“非伊朗人之境”这个概念，甚至还有“贾汗沙赫尔”这个“世界帝国”的概念。然而人们可以清楚地从萨珊帝国的意识形态中看到早期文明将自我与野蛮的他者相二元对立进行国家构建的模式。即使是贾汗沙赫尔与亚述帝国以及更早期近东君主宣称的“天下四方之王”也具有高度相似性，是一种人格化的宣称。甚至据说贾汗沙赫尔这个称呼被广泛使用，也是伊朗被阿拉伯人征服之后的事了。

可以这样说，古典伊朗的“天下观”仍然与青铜时代没有形成显著区别，其表述高度以国王为中心（几乎只用于王室铭文，而非为古典国家知识分子阶层的“公共政治语言”），强调君主主宰宇宙的神话宣称。这与古典帝国形成时期高度具有地理-文化-政治色彩的，道德化的“天下”具有明显区别，少有人文观念和普世性。这种对比就暗示伊朗复杂的地理环境的确对于古典伊朗社会产生了相当的影响，最高统治者还缺少自视为“已知世界秩序的维护者”的强烈自信，而是更务实地成为“国王中的国王”。